

THE
ADVOCACY
OPERATING
SYSTEM

*A framework for turning your customers
into your most credible growth channel*

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The Advocacy Operating System

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Foreword

Why I wrote this

Let me tell you about a deal I lost in 2014 that I think about all the time.

I was selling enterprise HR software. Big deal, seven figures, and I'd run a textbook sales process. Executive sponsorship. Technical validation. Business case built with the CFO's team. I had internal champions. I had the competitive advantage on features. I was confident.

We lost. And when I did the loss debrief, which I always did because losing teaches more than winning, the buyer told me something I've never forgotten. They said: 'Your product was probably the better fit. But we talked to three people who use [Competitor], and they were all enthusiastic. When we tried to find people who use your product, we couldn't find anyone talking about it. That made us nervous.'

Read that again. They chose the inferior product because the other vendor's customers were visibly enthusiastic and ours were invisible. We had happy customers. We had high NPS. We had great case studies on our website. But none of that mattered because it wasn't visible in the places where the buyer was looking.

That deal haunted me for years. And some version of it was happening across the industry. Great products losing to louder products. Companies with genuinely happy customers losing to companies whose customers were simply more visible.

I kept asking myself: why doesn't someone build a system for this? Why are we leaving the most credible marketing channel a company has to pure chance?

I spent 25 years selling enterprise software. SAP, Medallia, Cornerstone, ADP. I closed north of \$250 million in deals across those companies, and I can tell you exactly how most of those deals actually got done.

It wasn't the demo. It wasn't the ROI calculator. It wasn't even the sales process, though I'd like to think I ran a good one. What closed those deals, more often than I'm comfortable admitting, was a phone call the buyer made to someone they trusted. A former colleague. An ops leader at another company who happened to use the product. Someone in their network who could say, with no agenda, whether the thing actually worked.

I watched this pattern repeat for two decades. The buyer's internal reference call, the one my sales team didn't schedule and didn't know about, was almost always the moment the deal tipped. The best salespeople I worked with understood this instinctively. They didn't just sell to the prospect. They invested in making their existing customers successful enough, and visible enough, that when the next prospect asked around, the answer came back positive.

But here's the thing that always bothered me: nobody built a system for it.

Companies would spend millions on paid advertising, content marketing, SDR teams, trade shows, and all the other machinery of B2B growth. Then when it came to the single most credible channel they had, their own happy customers talking about them, the best

they could do was an occasional case study and a reference request that made the customer feel like they were doing the company a favor.

I started Kindling because I believe there's a better way. Not better in a marginal, incremental sense. Better in the way that product-led growth was better than the enterprise sales model it disrupted. A structural shift in how B2B companies grow, built on the simple observation that your customers are more credible than your marketing team, and the technology now exists to turn that credibility into a real channel.

This book lays out the framework for that shift. I'm calling it Advocacy-Led Growth, and I believe it represents the next significant evolution in how B2B SaaS companies build pipeline.

A few things I want to be upfront about before you read further.

First, I'm building a company around this thesis. Kindling is the platform designed to operationalize what this book describes. I'll reference it where it's relevant, but this book is not a product pitch. The ideas here are bigger than any one tool, and they'll work whether you use Kindling or build the systems yourself.

Second, I don't have a library of customer case studies to share with you. Kindling is early. We're in the market, the product is live, and we're working with our first cohort of companies. I won't invent results we haven't produced. What I do have is 25 years of pattern recognition from the buy side and the sell side of enterprise software, a deep understanding of the research that supports this thesis, and a conviction that the market is ready for this shift. Where I cite research, it's real. Where I share observations, they come from direct experience. Where I speculate, I'll tell you.

Third, this framework is designed to work alongside everything you're already doing, not replace it. If you're running a product-led motion, advocacy makes it convert better. If you're sales-led, advocacy gives your reps air cover. If you're doing content marketing, advocacy gives you content that your team literally cannot produce, because it comes from people who use the product and have no reason to lie about it.

I wrote this book for founders and marketing leaders at B2B SaaS companies who know something is broken about how they grow, who have happy customers they aren't leveraging, and who are looking for a framework that's both intellectually honest and practically useful.

I hope this is that framework.

Brian De Groodt
Boulder, Colorado
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CHAPTER 1

The Trust Shift

Something changed in how B2B buyers make decisions

There's a moment in every B2B purchase that matters more than any other. It happens outside your funnel. It's invisible to your analytics. Your sales team doesn't control it, and your marketing team didn't create it.

It's the moment when the buyer asks someone they trust whether your product actually works.

That someone might be a former colleague. It might be a connection on LinkedIn. It might be a person in a Slack community who mentioned your product six months ago. The buyer finds them, asks the question, and the answer they get carries more weight than every piece of content your marketing team has ever produced.

This isn't a new dynamic. People have always trusted other people more than they trust brands. What's new is the scale at which it happens and the degree to which it now determines outcomes.

The Research Is Clear

Forrester's 2023 B2B Brand and Communications Survey found that over 90% of B2B buyers trust peers in their industry when making purchase decisions. Further, 85% trust the customers of vendors in their industry. At the bottom of the trust ranking, with only 29% trust, were salespeople from vendors. Social media influencers weren't far above.

The pattern shows up across every major study of B2B buying behavior. The 2024 Edelman-LinkedIn B2B Thought Leadership Impact Report found that 75% of decision-makers and C-suite executives say a piece of thought leadership has led them to research a product or service they weren't previously considering. Nine out of ten said they would be more receptive to sales outreach from a company that consistently produces high-quality thought leadership content.

The TrustRadius 2024 B2B Buying Disconnect report tells a similar story from a different angle. The vast majority of buyers sought out peer conversations through their professional networks when making purchase decisions, and only 23% spoke with a vendor-supplied reference. Most of those peer conversations happen in places companies can't see or measure: LinkedIn messages, Slack channels, text threads, coffee conversations.

And the G2 2024 Buyer Behavior Report showed that public product review websites became the most-consulted information source for B2B buyers planning purchases, cited by 31% of respondents, up from just 13% in 2021. Independent peer forums and communities followed closely behind.

The trajectory is unmistakable. Buyers are increasingly relying on other buyers, not on vendors, for the information they need to make decisions.

What This Means for Growth

If you run marketing or sales at a B2B SaaS company, the implication of this research is uncomfortable but important: the most influential voices in your market are not on your payroll.

The practitioner who posts about your product on LinkedIn and reaches 2,000 of the exact people you're trying to sell to is doing something your brand account fundamentally cannot do, regardless of how much you spend. They're being trusted. Not because they have a big audience. Not because the content is polished. But because they're a peer, they use the product, and they have no obvious reason to say nice things about it unless the nice things are true.

This is the trust shift. It's not a trend. It's a structural change in how B2B purchasing decisions get made. And it creates an enormous opportunity for companies that figure out how to work with it rather than fight it.

The companies that figure this out will have a compounding advantage. Every piece of customer content creates more visibility, which attracts more customers, some of whom become advocates themselves. The trust gap between companies with active customer advocates and companies without them widens every quarter.

The companies that ignore it will spend more and more on channels that deliver less and less. They'll keep buying attention from an increasingly skeptical audience while their competitors earn it from people that audience already trusts.

The most valuable marketing asset a B2B company has is not content. It's the network of customers who would vouch for them if asked.

CHAPTER 2

How We Got Here

The evolution of B2B growth models

B2B software has cycled through growth paradigms, each one a response to what stopped working before. Understanding where we've been makes it clearer why advocacy-led growth is emerging now.

Sales-Led Growth: The Original Motion

For most of the history of enterprise software, growth was synonymous with sales. You built a product, hired a sales team, ran outbound campaigns, and controlled the conversation from first touch to close. The sales rep was the primary interface between the company and the buyer.

This model worked when buyers had limited access to information. If you wanted to understand what a piece of software could do, you had to talk to the vendor. The demo was the only way to see the product. The sales rep was the only source of competitive intelligence. The vendor controlled the narrative because they controlled the information.

Sales-led growth built enormous companies. It still works for complex, high-ACV enterprise deals where the buying process is inherently consultative. But its limitations

became clear as the market shifted. The cost of maintaining large sales teams scaled linearly with revenue targets. Buyers started doing their own research before talking to sales. And by the time a prospect booked a demo, they were often 70% or more through their decision, with opinions already formed from sources the sales team never touched.

Product-Led Growth: Let the Product Sell Itself

Product-led growth emerged as a response to sales-led's limitations. The thesis was elegant: if the product is good enough, let people try it. Remove friction. Offer a free tier. Optimize the onboarding flow. Let usage drive conversion, and let conversion drive revenue.

PLG produced some of the most remarkable growth stories in SaaS history. Slack, Zoom, Dropbox, Atlassian, and dozens of others proved that you could build billion-dollar companies with minimal (or no) outbound sales teams in the early stages. The product became the primary growth engine, and the go-to-market motion became a function of user experience rather than sales methodology.

But PLG has its own ceiling. When every product in a category has a free tier, the free tier stops being a differentiator. Conversion optimization has diminishing returns. And for products that solve complex problems for teams (not just individuals), the self-serve model breaks down because the buying decision involves multiple stakeholders who need social proof and organizational buy-in, not just a personal trial.

PLG also created a specific problem: it generates users, but not necessarily trust. A buyer who signs up for a free trial knows the product. They don't necessarily believe in it. The belief comes from somewhere else, from hearing other practitioners talk about it, from seeing it mentioned in their professional communities, from the peer who says "we use this and it changed how we work."

Content Marketing and Influencer Marketing: Renting Attention

Alongside (and sometimes overlapping with) PLG, content marketing became the dominant demand generation strategy for B2B SaaS. Blogs, whitepapers, webinars, podcasts, ebooks, gated content, nurture sequences, the content marketing industrial complex grew into a multi-billion dollar ecosystem.

Content marketing works. Good content educates buyers, builds brand awareness, and creates inbound demand. But it has a fundamental limitation: it's all branded. No matter how useful the content is, the buyer knows it was created by the company selling the product. That awareness creates a credibility discount. The content might be accurate, but the reader applies a filter: "Of course they'd say their approach works. They're selling it."

Influencer marketing attempted to solve this credibility gap by borrowing trust from people with audiences. In B2B, this has grown into a significant practice. Brands pay industry figures, consultants, and professional content creators to talk about their products. The content appears on the influencer's profile, carrying their credibility.

The problem is that this model is essentially advertising wearing a different outfit. Sophisticated B2B buyers know the influencer got paid. They apply the same credibility discount they apply to branded content, perhaps with slightly more generosity, but the discount is still there. The influencer's enthusiasm was purchased, and the buyer knows it.

Traditional Customer Advocacy: Good Instinct, Wrong Execution

The closest precursor to what I'm describing in this book is the customer advocacy category. Companies like Influitive built platforms that helped brands gamify customer engagement through portals, points, challenges, and rewards. Customers could complete activities (leave a review, participate in a case study, take a reference call) and earn points or prizes.

The instinct behind traditional advocacy is correct: happy customers are valuable, and there should be a system for engaging them. But the execution missed the mark in a few important ways.

First, most advocacy platforms are internal-facing. They create portals that live inside the company's ecosystem, disconnected from the public platforms where buyers actually form opinions. A customer completing a challenge in a gamified portal is not the same as a customer posting about your product on LinkedIn where 2,000 of your target buyers can see it.

Second, the gamification model manufactures engagement. When a customer is completing tasks to earn points, the engagement feels like exactly what it is: someone doing something for a reward. That's different from a customer who chooses, on their own terms, to share their genuine experience publicly.

Third, traditional advocacy tools were built for customer marketing and customer success teams, not for growth. They support activities like reference management, review collection, and community engagement, all valuable, but none of them designed to function as a pipeline channel.

The Gap

So here's where we stand. Sales-led growth still works but struggles with trust and scale. Product-led growth still works but struggles with differentiation and organizational buy-in. Content marketing still works but carries a permanent credibility discount. Influencer marketing attempts to borrow credibility but at a cost that buyers see through. And traditional advocacy has the right instinct but the wrong execution.

What's missing is a growth model built on the thing buyers actually trust: genuine, public endorsement from people who use the product and have no obligation to say nice things about it.

That's the gap Advocacy-Led Growth fills.

CHAPTER 3

What Is Advocacy-Led Growth

A formal definition and why the category matters

Let me define what I mean precisely, because the words matter and because this concept is frequently confused with things it is not.

Advocacy-Led Growth is a B2B go-to-market motion where verified customers create public content on social platforms, turning word-of-mouth into a measurable, scalable pipeline channel.

Every word in that definition is deliberate. Let me unpack them.

Verified customers. Not hired creators. Not professional influencers. Not affiliates. People who actually use the product, whose customer status can be confirmed, and whose experience is real. The verification is what creates the credibility. Without it, you're doing influencer marketing.

Create public content. Not testimonials locked behind a sales team's email. Not reviews on a gated portal. Content that lives on LinkedIn, X, YouTube, and other platforms where B2B buyers spend time and form opinions. The content has to be visible to the people you're trying to reach.

On social platforms. The channel is not owned. It's not your blog, your email list, or your community portal. It's the platforms where your buyers already are, scrolling, reading, and forming impressions about the tools and practices that matter to their work.

Turning word-of-mouth into a measurable channel. This is the operational leap. Word-of-mouth has always existed. What hasn't existed is the infrastructure to recruit advocates, support them, track what they create, measure its impact, and compensate them fairly. ALG takes something that used to happen by accident and gives it the structure of a real growth motion.

Scalable. A single customer testimonial is nice. A system that continuously produces authentic customer content across dozens of advocates is a channel. The difference is infrastructure.

Pipeline channel. The goal is not brand awareness for its own sake, though that's a byproduct. The goal is measurable influence on pipeline: deals where prospects encountered advocate content before or during their buying process, and that exposure contributed to their decision.

What ALG Is Not

Because this is a new framework, it's worth being explicit about what it isn't, since the most common reaction I get is people trying to fit it into a category they already know.

ALG is not influencer marketing. Influencer marketing starts with finding people who have audiences and paying them to talk about your product. ALG starts with finding customers who have genuine experience and giving them a reason and a platform to share it. The content creation model, the compensation structure, the relationship dynamics, and the credibility mechanism are all different.

ALG is not affiliate marketing. Affiliates earn commissions for driving conversions through tracked links. The incentive is tied to the transaction, not to the content. ALG compensates advocates for creating content regardless of whether that specific post drives a traceable sale. The value is in the content and the trust it builds, not in a clickthrough.

ALG is not customer marketing. Customer marketing encompasses a broad set of activities: onboarding, adoption, expansion, retention, community, events, and more. ALG is specifically about the pipeline generation that comes from customers creating public content. It's one channel within the broader customer marketing ecosystem, not a replacement for it.

ALG is not a replacement for PLG or SLG. It's a layer that makes both work better. Product-led funnels convert at higher rates when prospects have already seen customers vouching for the product. Sales cycles compress when the buyer's network is already warm. Advocacy doesn't compete with your existing growth motions. It amplifies them.

Why the Category Matters

There's an important strategic reason to define ALG as a distinct category rather than bundling it into "customer marketing" or "advocacy" or "influencer" or any other existing label.

Categories shape how companies allocate budget. When a VP of Marketing looks at their budget, they see line items: paid media, content, events, SDR team, tools. If advocacy isn't its own line item, it gets funded from the scraps of whatever other budget it resembles most. If it looks like influencer marketing, it competes with influencer spend. If it looks like customer marketing, it gets buried in a CS budget that's already stretched thin.

Defining ALG as its own motion, with its own budget, its own metrics, and its own operational infrastructure, is what makes it real inside an organization. It's the difference between "we do some customer advocacy stuff" and "we run an advocacy-led growth program that generates measurable pipeline."

That distinction might seem like semantics. It's not. It's the difference between a hobby and a strategy.

CHAPTER 4

The Three Pillars

What has to be true for ALG to work

For Advocacy-Led Growth to function as a real channel, not just a nice idea, three things have to be true simultaneously. Remove any one of them and the whole thing collapses.

Pillar 1: Authenticity Is Structural, Not Aspirational

The reason customer content works is because it's real. The moment it feels manufactured, the trust evaporates. You don't get a second chance at this. If a buyer reads an advocate's post and thinks "this reads like a marketing team wrote it," you've lost not just that impression but that buyer's trust in the entire channel.

This means authenticity can't be a vibe or a brand guideline. It has to be built into the structure of how the program operates. The advocates are verified product users, not just anyone with an audience. The compensation is transparent, published rates that everyone can see, not backroom negotiations that make the arrangement feel shady. The content is in the advocate's voice about their actual experience, not scripted talking points reviewed by a brand committee until every trace of humanity has been edited out.

Authenticity is the mechanism, not the marketing angle. It's not something you claim in your positioning. It's something that either exists in the content or doesn't. And buyers are remarkably good at telling the difference.

Pillar 2: The Channel Is Public, Not Owned

Traditional advocacy lives inside your ecosystem. Portals, email programs, reference databases, community forums. These are valuable, but they are not what I mean by Advocacy-Led Growth.

ALG lives outside, on the platforms where buyers actually form opinions. A customer who leaves a G2 review is doing advocacy. A customer who posts about your product on LinkedIn, where their 900 connections (including 200 people who look exactly like your ICP) can see it, is doing Advocacy-Led Growth. One feeds your sales team with reference material. The other feeds your pipeline with trust.

The distinction matters because public content has network effects that owned-channel content doesn't. A LinkedIn post gets liked, which gets shown to more people, who comment, which gets shown to even more people. One post from one advocate can reach thousands of qualified buyers through the organic distribution of the platform. Your G2 review page, however well-maintained, doesn't have that dynamic.

Public content also has permanence. A reference call helps one deal. A LinkedIn post sits in the feed, gets reshared, gets found through search, and continues working long after it was published. The compounding effect of advocacy content on public platforms is one of the most powerful aspects of this entire model.

Pillar 3: It's a System, Not a Moment

Most companies treat customer enthusiasm as a happy accident. Someone posts about them, the marketing team screenshots it for a slide deck, and then nothing happens. There's no follow-up. There's no system to encourage more of it. There's no infrastructure to identify who might be willing to create content, support them in doing so, or measure what impact it had.

ALG requires infrastructure. Recruiting mechanisms. Content support systems. Performance tracking. Compensation workflows. Review processes. Measurement frameworks. The companies that will succeed at advocacy-led growth won't be the ones with the most enthusiastic customers. They'll be the ones who built the system to support and sustain that enthusiasm at scale.

The system creates the conditions for content to happen. It makes it easy, rewarding, and frictionless for customers to share their experience. But, and this is critically important, it never makes it mandatory. The system is an enabler, not an assignment engine. This distinction is so central to how ALG works that it gets its own chapter.

How the Pillars Reinforce Each Other

These three pillars are not independent. They form an interlocking system where each one strengthens the others.

Authenticity makes the public channel work. If the content weren't genuine, publishing it on LinkedIn would be counterproductive. Buyers would see through it, and the advocate's credibility (and yours) would suffer. The structural authenticity of verified customers speaking in their own voice is what makes public distribution valuable rather than risky.

The public channel makes the system worthwhile. If advocate content lived only in internal portals and reference databases, you wouldn't need much infrastructure. A spreadsheet and a few emails would do. It's the scale and network effects of public platforms that create the need for a real system: tracking, measurement, compensation, review processes, and the operational discipline to run it all.

The system makes authenticity sustainable. Without infrastructure, advocacy depends on individual heroics. A CSM who happens to know which customers are vocal. A marketing person who manually tracks mentions. These efforts burn out quickly. The system ensures that advocacy is a repeatable, scalable operation that doesn't depend on any single person's energy or attention.

What Breaks When a Pillar Is Missing

Remove authenticity and you get influencer marketing. The content is public and there's a system, but the credibility isn't there. Buyers see through it. Engagement may be high, but trust is low, and trust is what converts.

Remove the public channel and you get traditional customer advocacy. The content is authentic and there's a system (portals, gamification, reference management), but it's invisible to the market. It helps your sales team with specific deals, but it doesn't build the ambient trust that warms pipeline at scale.

Remove the system and you get happy accidents. Customers occasionally post nice things about you, and your marketing team occasionally notices. The content is authentic and public, but it's sporadic, unmeasured, and unscalable. It's nice when it happens. It's not a growth channel.

All three pillars have to be present, simultaneously, for Advocacy-Led Growth to function as a real motion. This is what makes it genuinely different from the adjacent categories it's often confused with.

CHAPTER 5

The Organic Principle

Why advocate content must be voluntary

This is the chapter I care most about getting right, because it addresses the question that every marketing leader asks when they first hear about advocacy-led growth:

"How do you make sure the advocates actually produce content?"

The answer is: you don't make them. And that's the point.

Advocate content is organic or it's worthless. Customers create content when they have something worth saying. They might be inspired by a product update that solved a problem they'd been complaining about for months. They might have just finished a quarter where the product delivered results they're proud of. They might be at a conference and want to share what they learned. They might just have a slow Tuesday morning and feel like writing about their workflow.

That inspiration can be supported. It can be prompted. It can be compensated. But it cannot be assigned, scheduled, or expected.

The moment you start telling customers what to post and when to post it, you've crossed the line from advocacy into advertising. And buyers can tell the difference. That difference is the entire value proposition of this channel.

What "Organic" Actually Means in Practice

Let me be specific about what I mean, because "organic" is one of those words that can mean whatever people want it to mean.

In an ALG program, advocates have access to a library of content briefs: structured prompts that give them a starting point and a framework if they want one. Think of these as a menu at a restaurant, not as a work order from a manager. The briefs suggest topics and angles. "How do you use [Product] in your daily workflow?" "What changed after you switched to [Product]?" "What's a feature most people don't know about?" These are jumping-off points, not scripts.

Advocates choose which briefs interest them, if any. They create content on their own schedule. There are no deadlines. There's no minimum posting requirement. There's no leaderboard ranking advocates by output. There's no automated nudge sequence that says "you haven't posted in 14 days."

Some advocates will create content every week. Some will create once a quarter. Some will sign up, create one piece, and never create again. All of that is fine. The program is designed to support whatever level of engagement feels right to each individual advocate, because these are people with real jobs who happen to use a product they like. Their job is not to create content for you.

The system's job is to make content creation easy, rewarding, and friction-free for the advocates who do want to create. Fast review turnaround (under 24 hours). Simple

submission process. Transparent compensation paid promptly. Optional coaching for advocates who want to improve their writing or video skills. A library of ideas they can browse when inspiration doesn't strike on its own.

Company Moments as Inspiration, Not Mandates

There are natural moments in a company's lifecycle that tend to inspire advocate content. A major product release. An annual user conference. A significant milestone. A new integration that makes the product work better with tools the advocate's team already uses.

An ALG program can surface these moments to advocates as context that might spark an idea. "We just shipped a major update to our reporting dashboard. If you've tried it and have thoughts, we'd love to see what you think." That's context. That's inspiration. It's an invitation, not an instruction.

What it is not: "We need 10 posts about the new dashboard feature by Friday. Here are the talking points." That's an influencer campaign. It produces content that reads like an influencer campaign. And the buyers who see it will treat it accordingly.

Why This Is a Competitive Advantage

The organic principle isn't just the right thing to do. It's a competitive moat.

Every influencer platform in the market is built on assignment and scheduling. Their entire product architecture assumes the brand directs the content. Briefs with deadlines. Campaign calendars. Completion rate dashboards. These companies literally cannot adopt the organic model without rebuilding their products and their go-to-market from scratch.

Traditional advocacy platforms have a similar structural constraint. They're built on gamification: points, levels, challenges, task completion. The engagement is manufactured by design. Removing the gamification would mean removing their core value proposition.

A company that builds its advocacy program around organic content has an advantage that competitors built on assignment models cannot easily replicate. The content is more credible. The advocates are more engaged (because they're participating voluntarily, not completing assignments). The buyers are more trusting. And the economics are better, because you're not paying for manufactured enthusiasm that depletes over time, you're supporting genuine enthusiasm that sustains itself.

If you have to tell your customers to talk about you, they're not really advocating for you.

CHAPTER 6

Who Creates the Content

Customers, influencers, and employees are not interchangeable

One of the most common mistakes companies make when they start thinking about advocacy is treating all non-branded content as equivalent. A LinkedIn post from a customer, a sponsored post from an influencer, and a thought leadership piece from your VP of Marketing are all "authentic content from a real person." But they are fundamentally different in how buyers perceive them, and that perception determines their value.

The Customer Advantage

A verified customer who posts about your product has three things that no other content creator can replicate.

First, they have experiential authority. They don't just know about the product in theory. They use it every day to do their actual job. When they say "this feature saved our team 10 hours a week," the claim carries weight because the reader knows it comes from lived experience, not from a demo script.

Second, they have peer credibility. If the advocate is a Director of Marketing Operations posting about a marketing tool, other Directors of Marketing Operations pay attention. The reader sees themselves in the advocate. "This person has my job, faces my problems, and found something that works." That identification is enormously powerful and it's something neither a brand nor an influencer can create.

Third, they have no obvious agenda. Yes, in an ALG program, advocates receive compensation. And yes, that compensation should be disclosed per FTC guidelines. But the dynamic is fundamentally different from an influencer deal. The advocate was a customer first. They chose to participate in the program because they already liked the product. The compensation is a thank-you for their time, not a fee for their opinion. Buyers understand this distinction intuitively.

Why Influencers Are Different

Professional B2B influencers serve a legitimate purpose. They have audiences, they create well-crafted content, and they can generate awareness quickly. For product launches, event promotion, and top-of-funnel reach, influencer marketing can be effective.

But influencers have a structural limitation when it comes to trust: their business model is creating sponsored content. Everyone knows this. When a B2B influencer with 50,000 LinkedIn followers posts enthusiastically about a product, the sophisticated buyer's first thought is "I wonder how much they got paid for this." The content might be perfectly accurate, but the credibility discount is baked in.

There's also a depth problem. Most B2B influencers are not daily users of the products they promote. They've been briefed, they've seen a demo, maybe they've used the product enough to speak intelligently about it. But they lack the firsthand operational experience that makes customer content so compelling. They can tell you what the product does. A

customer can tell you what it's like to use it on a Tuesday afternoon when three things are going wrong and you need it to work.

The Employee Content Layer

Employee advocacy, particularly executive thought leadership, is valuable and should be part of any B2B company's content strategy. Your CEO should be posting on LinkedIn. Your product leaders should be sharing what they're building and why. Your sales team should be active and visible.

But employee content, however authentic the individual might be, comes from someone who works for the company. The reader knows the poster has a financial interest in the product succeeding. That doesn't make the content worthless, but it does mean it occupies a different trust tier than content from an external customer.

The smartest companies will run all three: employee thought leadership for brand visibility, selective influencer partnerships for reach, and an advocacy program for trust. They're not competing strategies. They're complementary channels that serve different purposes in the buyer's journey.

But if you had to pick one to invest in first, and you're optimizing for pipeline rather than awareness, advocacy wins. Because trust is the scarcest resource in B2B, and customers are the most trusted voice.

CHAPTER 7

The Economics

How advocacy changes the math on customer acquisition

Advocacy-Led Growth is not a feel-good initiative. It's an economic argument. And the math, once you lay it out, is hard to ignore.

The Rising Cost of Rented Attention

LinkedIn is the dominant B2B advertising platform, and it's expensive. CPMs (cost per thousand impressions) on LinkedIn Sponsored Content typically range from \$30 to \$80, with some industries and audiences pushing above \$100. Cost per click ranges from \$4 to \$12 or more. These costs have been climbing steadily as more B2B advertisers compete for the same audiences.

A B2B SaaS company spending \$10,000 per month on LinkedIn ads might generate 125,000 to 333,000 impressions. Those impressions come from the company page, which means they carry all the credibility limitations of branded content. The buyer sees the company name, the "Promoted" label, and applies the standard filter: this is an ad.

The returns from that spend are directly tied to the spend itself. Stop paying and the impressions stop. There's no residual value. No compounding effect. Every month starts

from zero.

The Economics of Earned Attention

Fred Reichheld, the Bain fellow who created the Net Promoter Score, introduced a concept called the Earned Growth Rate in a 2021 Harvard Business Review article. The framework distinguishes between "earned" customers (those acquired through referrals and word-of-mouth) and "bought" customers (those acquired through advertising and promotional spending).

Reichheld's research, conducted with his colleagues Darci Darnell and Maureen Burns, argues that earned customers are fundamentally more valuable. They retain at higher rates. They expand more. They cost less to acquire. And critically, they are more likely to become advocates themselves, creating a compounding cycle that bought customers rarely produce.

He went further, suggesting that companies with the highest NPS scores, the strongest track record of enriching customer lives, generate total shareholder returns two to three times the market average. The earned growth rate, as an accounting-based metric, was designed to make this visible in ways that NPS alone could not.

The relevance to Advocacy-Led Growth is direct: ALG is a systematic way to increase your earned growth rate. Every customer who creates public content is generating earned attention. Every buyer who encounters that content and enters your pipeline is an earned lead. The cost structure, the retention characteristics, and the downstream advocacy potential of those leads are all superior to leads generated through paid channels.

Earned Media Value: A Practical Comparison

One useful (if imperfect) way to quantify the economic value of advocacy content is through Earned Media Value (EMV): the equivalent cost of generating the same impressions through paid advertising.

Here's a simple illustration. Suppose your advocacy program has 15 active advocates who collectively publish 30 pieces of content per month on LinkedIn. Each piece averages 2,000 impressions. That's 60,000 organic impressions per month from trusted voices.

If you used LinkedIn's conservative floor CPM of \$30, generating those same 60,000 impressions through paid advertising would cost \$1,800. But there's a qualitative difference the CPM comparison doesn't capture: those 60,000 impressions came from individual profiles, not a company page. Research consistently shows that content from personal profiles generates five to ten times the engagement of equivalent company page content. So the effective value of those 60,000 organic impressions is significantly higher than \$1,800 worth of branded ads.

Now add the compounding factor. Paid impressions evaporate when you stop paying. Advocate content continues generating impressions for weeks and months after publication. A strong LinkedIn post can generate engagement for seven to fourteen days, and can surface in search results and feed algorithms long after that.

The Budget Reallocation Frame

This is an important point for how you position advocacy internally: ALG is not new budget. It's reallocated budget.

Most B2B SaaS companies are already spending money on paid social, content production, and influencer partnerships. The advocacy argument is that a portion of that existing spend can be redirected toward a channel that produces more credible content, at a lower effective cost, with compounding rather than linear returns.

For a company spending \$10,000 per month on LinkedIn ads, redirecting \$3,000 to \$5,000 per month toward advocate compensation might generate comparable or superior reach, with dramatically higher engagement and trust metrics, while the remaining paid budget continues serving its purpose for product announcements and hard CTAs.

The framing matters because it determines who says yes. A VP of Marketing who hears "I need new budget for an advocacy program" has a harder conversation with finance than one who says "I want to reallocate 30% of our LinkedIn ad spend to a channel that generates more trusted impressions at a lower effective cost."

A Worked Example: The First-Year Economics

Let me walk through what the first-year economics of an advocacy program might look like for a hypothetical B2B SaaS company. I want to be explicit that these are illustrative projections based on reasonable assumptions, not results from a specific company. The actual numbers for your organization will depend on your customer base, your market, your advocates' audiences, and dozens of other variables. But the structure of the math is instructive.

Imagine a Series B SaaS company currently spending \$10,000 per month on LinkedIn ads. They decide to reallocate \$3,000 of that monthly budget to fund an advocacy program, keeping \$7,000 in standard paid campaigns.

In Month 1 through Month 3, they recruit and onboard 12 advocates. Content starts appearing in Month 2, slowly at first. By Month 3, the program is producing approximately 15 pieces of content per month, averaging 2,000 impressions each. That is 30,000 organic impressions per month from trusted personal profiles.

At a conservative \$30 CPM benchmark, those 30,000 impressions have an earned media value of approximately \$900 per month. The program is spending \$3,000 per month (advocate compensation, platform costs) to generate \$900 in equivalent media value. On pure EMV math, it looks like a losing proposition.

But EMV alone drastically understates the value. Those 30,000 impressions came from individual practitioners, not a brand account. The engagement rate on those posts is likely three to five times higher than company page content. The people engaging with the content are exactly the personas the company is trying to reach. And the content sits permanently in the LinkedIn ecosystem, continuing to generate impressions for weeks after publication.

By Month 6, the program has 18 active advocates producing 30 to 40 pieces per month. The content library now contains over 100 posts. Monthly organic impressions have grown to 70,000 or more. EMV at the \$30 floor is roughly \$2,100 per month, but with the engagement premium and the compounding library, the effective value is considerably higher.

And here is where the real economics kick in: by Month 6, the company starts seeing advocate content surface in pipeline conversations. A prospect mentions they saw a customer post. A deal accelerates after the AE shares an advocate's experience. These pipeline influence data points are hard to attribute precisely, but even a single deal influenced by advocacy content can generate returns that dwarf the program's annual cost.

By Month 12, the math typically inverts. The advocacy program is generating more effective impressions, at higher engagement rates, with compounding persistence, at a lower effective cost per trusted impression than the remaining \$7,000 in standard LinkedIn ads. And unlike the paid campaigns, the value doesn't evaporate when the budget stops. The content library continues working.

I present this example not as a guarantee but as a framework for how to think about the investment. The numbers will vary. The trajectory, paid down, earned up, compounds over time, is what the underlying dynamics predict.

CHAPTER 8

Amplification

Where organic advocacy meets paid distribution

There's a natural ceiling to organic reach. An advocate with 900 LinkedIn connections might generate 2,000 impressions on a good post. That's valuable, but it's limited to their network. If the post is exceptional, if it's exactly the kind of content you want your entire ICP to see, you want a way to push it further.

This is where Thought Leader Ads enter the picture, and where the advocacy model and the paid media model converge in a way that neither could achieve on its own.

What Thought Leader Ads Are

LinkedIn's Thought Leader Ad format lets a company put paid spend behind an organic post from an individual person's profile. The ad appears in the feed looking like a normal personal post: the person's name, photo, and headline, with a small "Promoted by [Company]" label underneath.

This is a meaningful product innovation because it preserves the trust mechanism of personal content while giving it the targeting and reach of paid distribution. The buyer sees a post from a real person, not a company ad. The content keeps its authenticity. The

company gets to target its ICP at scale.

Why This Matters for Advocacy

In an ALG program, Thought Leader Ads are the amplification layer. The process is straightforward: advocates create organic content on their own terms. Some of that content performs exceptionally well, generating high engagement from the advocate's own network. The company identifies these high performers and, with the advocate's explicit permission, puts paid spend behind them.

The sequence matters here. The content was not created for advertising. It was created because a customer had something worth saying. It proved itself organically before any paid spend was applied. The paid spend simply extends the audience. This distinction is important because it means the content that gets amplified has already passed the market's test. You're not guessing which creative will perform. You're promoting content that already proved it resonates.

The performance advantage is significant. Because Thought Leader Ads look like personal posts, they generate higher engagement rates than standard sponsored content. Higher engagement rates feed LinkedIn's auction algorithm, which means lower cost per click. Lower CPCs mean more traffic per dollar. And that traffic arrives warmer, because the prospect just read a genuine customer account of using the product, not a marketing pitch.

The Principle: Organic First, Amplification Second

The integrity of this entire approach depends on one principle: advocates are never asked to create content for the purpose of advertising.

The content comes first. It's organic. It's voluntary. It reflects the advocate's genuine experience. Amplification is a second-order decision made after the content exists and has proven itself. This is the opposite of how influencer campaigns work, where the content is created specifically for the campaign.

If you find yourself asking advocates to create content with the specific intent of running it as an ad, you've crossed the line. The advocate should be creating content because they want to share their experience. The company should be amplifying it because the audience responded to it. The causal chain matters.

Practical Guidance

For companies exploring Thought Leader Ads as part of their advocacy program, a few operational principles:

Start by allocating 20 to 30 percent of your existing LinkedIn ad spend to Thought Leader Ads. Run them alongside standard campaigns, not instead of them. Standard sponsored content still serves a purpose for product announcements and direct-response CTAs. Thought Leader Ads are for trust-building and mid-funnel warming.

Select content for amplification based on organic performance data, not based on what the brand wishes the advocate had said. The audience already voted with their engagement. Trust that signal.

Always communicate with the advocate before sponsoring their post. Explain what you're doing, that they'll see increased visibility on their profile, and that it's entirely their choice to approve the sponsorship. LinkedIn requires advocate approval, which is a good safeguard.

Rotate creative every two to three weeks. The advocacy program provides a continuous supply of new content, which is one of its structural advantages over traditional ad creative that has to be produced from scratch.

Track side-by-side performance: TLA campaigns versus standard sponsored content. The comparison, over time, makes the case for continued budget reallocation in a way that no amount of theory can match.

The Advocacy-to-Amplification Pipeline

Let me describe what this looks like as a repeatable process, week over week, because the operational cadence is what turns Thought Leader Ads from an occasional experiment into a consistent channel.

Each week, the person managing the advocacy program reviews the content activity log. They look at every piece of advocate content published in the previous seven to fourteen days and note which posts exceeded the program's average engagement rate. They look at which posts generated comments from people who match the company's ICP. They look at which posts were saved or shared more than usual.

From that review, they identify one to three posts that are strong candidates for amplification. Not every high-performing post is a good TLA candidate. The post needs to be a text or single-image format (LinkedIn's current constraint). It should say something about the product or the advocate's experience that would be relevant to a cold audience, not just to the advocate's existing network. And the advocate needs to be someone who would be comfortable with increased visibility on their profile.

The advocate gets a personal message: 'Your post did really well organically. We think it would resonate with a broader audience of [target persona]. Would you be open to us

putting some promotion behind it? You'd see more profile views and connection requests as a result.' Most advocates say yes. Some say no, and that's fine. It's always their choice.

If the advocate agrees, the marketing team creates the campaign in LinkedIn Campaign Manager within a day or two while the post is still fresh. They set targeting to the company's ICP, allocate a portion of the weekly TLA budget, and launch. The campaign runs for two to three weeks, after which it's replaced with a new high-performing post from a different advocate.

Over the course of a quarter, this cadence produces 8 to 12 amplified advocate posts, each targeted at the company's ICP, each with the credibility of a genuine customer voice. The cumulative data from these campaigns, compared side-by-side against standard sponsored content running simultaneously, builds the case for ongoing budget reallocation more persuasively than any pitch deck could.

What the Buyer Sees

It's worth thinking about this from the buyer's perspective, because that's where the value is actually created.

A buyer is scrolling LinkedIn on a Wednesday morning. Between posts from their connections, they see a promoted post from someone they don't know. The post is from a Director of Customer Success at a company they've never heard of. The Director is talking about how they use a particular software tool to reduce their team's response time. The post includes specific details: the workflow they set up, the metric that improved, the feature that made the difference. At the bottom, a small label says 'Promoted by [Company].'

The buyer reads the post and thinks: this person has my job. They're dealing with the same problem I'm dealing with. And they found something that actually helped. The post doesn't read like an ad. It reads like a colleague sharing what works.

That buyer might visit the company's website. They might not, at least not today. But the impression has been made. The product name has been associated with a real practitioner, a real problem solved, and a real result. When the buyer eventually enters a buying cycle for this category of software, that impression is in the background. It's trust that was earned, not attention that was rented.

That is the output of the entire Advocacy-Led Growth system. Not impressions. Not clicks. Trust, deposited in the minds of buyers who will make decisions months from now. Every piece of advocate content, organic and amplified, is a deposit in a trust bank that compounds over time.

CHAPTER 9

Building the System

From strategy to operations

The gap between understanding Advocacy-Led Growth conceptually and running it operationally is significant. Most companies that attempt advocacy programs fail not because the thesis is wrong but because they underestimate the operational infrastructure required.

What follows is a summary of what it takes to build and run an ALG program. This draws from the operational framework we've developed at Kindling, tested through our consulting engagements, and refined into what we call the Advocacy Operating System.

Phase 1: Foundation

Before recruiting a single advocate, you need to make five foundational decisions.

First, define your Ideal Advocate Profile. Not every customer is a good advocate. The best candidates are people who use the product regularly, work in roles that your target buyers identify with, have some presence on social platforms (they don't need a huge following, but they should post occasionally), and have a genuine positive relationship with the product. Your customer success team usually knows who these people are.

Second, design your compensation model. Advocates should be paid transparently for their time. Published rates, per content type, visible to everyone. Typical ranges for B2B SaaS advocacy programs run from \$50 to \$150 for a LinkedIn text post, \$150 to \$300 for short video content, and up from there for longer formats. The rates should reflect the value of the advocate's time and expertise, not the minimum you can get away with.

Third, write your content guidelines. What topics are encouraged? What's off-limits? How much creative freedom do advocates have? What are the FTC disclosure requirements? The guidelines should be clear and concise. A two-page document, not a thirty-page brand manual.

Fourth, build your content brief library. These are the optional prompts advocates can draw from when they want to create content but aren't sure where to start. A good brief library has a mix of evergreen prompts ("how I use the product in my workflow") and moment-driven prompts tied to product launches, conferences, or industry events. Remember: these are a menu, not a task list.

Fifth, set up your infrastructure. A platform for managing the program (this is what Kindling is built for), payout processing (we use Stripe Connect), content tracking, and performance measurement.

Phase 2: Recruitment

Advocate recruitment should be warm, personal, and respectful. The best approach is a personal introduction from someone the customer already trusts, typically their customer success manager or an executive at your company.

The message should convey three things: we value you as a customer, we're launching a program that rewards customers for sharing their experience publicly, and we'd love for

you to be one of the first people in it. The tone is invitation, not recruitment.

Expect conversion rates in the range of 40-60% from warm outreach to expressed interest, and 70-85% from expressed interest to enrolled advocate. These rates are dramatically higher than cold outreach because you're asking people to do something they likely would have done for free if they'd thought of it.

Start small. Ten to fifteen advocates in your first cohort is plenty. You'll learn more from running a small program well than from trying to scale before the operational kinks are worked out.

Phase 3: Activation and Support

Once advocates are onboarded, the program's job is to make content creation as easy and rewarding as possible. Share available briefs. Be responsive to questions. Review submitted content quickly (24-hour turnaround is the standard we hold ourselves to). Pay promptly and transparently.

Content review is a critical operational function. Every piece of advocate content should be reviewed before publication for factual accuracy, FTC compliance (is the disclosure present?), and brand alignment. The review should be fast, light-touch, and respectful of the advocate's voice. You're checking for problems, not editing for style. If the content sounds like the advocate wrote it, that's a feature, not a bug.

If content volume is lower than expected, the response should never be to pressure advocates. Instead, ask: are the briefs inspiring enough? Is the compensation fair? Is the process easy enough? Is the review turnaround fast enough? The problem is always on the program side, never on the advocate side.

Phase 4: Optimization

After 60 to 90 days of operation, you'll have enough data to optimize. Which content types generate the most engagement? Which briefs are advocates gravitating toward? Which advocates are most active, and what can you learn from their approach? Where is content showing up in pipeline conversations?

Use this data to refresh the brief library, adjust the rate card if certain content types are generating outsized value, provide coaching to advocates who want it, and recruit your second cohort based on what you learned from the first.

This is also the phase where Thought Leader Ad amplification typically begins, since you now have organic performance data to identify the best candidates for paid promotion.

Phase 5: Transition to Internal Ownership

If you started your advocacy program with external help, whether from Kindling's consulting team or another resource, there comes a point where the program needs to be owned internally. The goal of any DFY engagement is to make itself unnecessary.

Transition works best when it's gradual. The internal program owner shadows the external team for two to three weeks, running the operations with coaching. Then they operate independently for another two to three weeks with the external team available for questions. By the end of that month, they should be comfortable running every recurring process: publishing briefs, reviewing content, processing payouts, communicating with advocates, and producing performance reports.

The handoff should include a complete operations manual documenting every process step by step. Not strategic overview, not high-level guidance, but literal click-by-click

procedures for every task. This manual is the insurance policy that protects the program if the internal owner changes roles, goes on leave, or gets pulled into other priorities.

Common Operational Mistakes

Having worked through the operational details of building advocacy programs, I've seen patterns in what goes wrong. Here are the most common mistakes and how to avoid them.

Slow content review kills momentum. If an advocate submits content on Monday and doesn't hear back until Thursday, their enthusiasm drops measurably. The 24-hour review SLA is not a nice-to-have. It is the single most important operational discipline in the program. Every day of review delay reduces the likelihood that the advocate will create a second piece of content.

Vague briefs produce no content. A brief that says "write about your experience with our product" gives the advocate nothing to work with. Good briefs give a specific angle, a starting question, and an example of what the output might look like. They reduce the creative burden without constraining the advocate's voice.

Inconsistent compensation destroys trust. If payouts are late, unclear, or inconsistent, advocates lose confidence in the program fast. Use a payment processor that handles the mechanics reliably (we use Stripe Connect), and send a line-item breakdown with every payment so advocates know exactly what they earned and why.

Over-editing advocate content backfires. The instinct of every marketing team is to polish content until it shines. Resist this. If an advocate's post reads like a marketing team wrote it, you've destroyed the thing that made it valuable. Review for factual accuracy and compliance. Leave the voice alone.

Treating quiet advocates as a problem. Some advocates will create content every week. Some will create once a quarter. Some will go silent for months and then produce something exceptional. This is normal. Advocacy is voluntary. The moment you start treating inactivity as a problem to be solved through nudges, reminders, or guilt, you've crossed the line from support into pressure. If overall content volume is low, the issue is usually with the briefs, the compensation, or the onboarding, not with the advocates.

Failing to close the loop with sales. If your sales team doesn't know the advocacy program exists, the pipeline influence you're generating is invisible. Brief the sales team. Show them where to find advocate content. Train them to share it in deal cycles. And create a simple mechanism for them to report when a prospect mentions advocate content. Without this feedback loop, you can't measure the thing that matters most.

CHAPTER 10

Measurement That Matters

The metrics that tell you whether it's working

Measurement is what separates ALG from "we do some customer advocacy stuff." Without rigorous tracking, advocacy is a vibe. With it, it's a channel that can earn and defend its budget.

Leading Indicators

Leading indicators tell you whether the program is healthy and active. They're the metrics you monitor weekly.

Active Advocates: The number of enrolled advocates who have published at least one piece of content in the last 30 days. This is your roster health metric. If it's declining, something about the program isn't working for advocates.

Content Velocity: The total number of pieces published per month across all advocates. This tells you whether the program is producing at a sustainable rate. There's no universal benchmark here because it depends on your cohort size and program maturity.

Brief Pickup Rate: The percentage of available briefs that at least one advocate chooses to create from. This measures whether your briefs are inspiring. If pickup rates are low, the briefs need to be more interesting or relevant, not the advocates need to be more productive. This is not a completion rate. It's a signal about the quality of your prompts.

Review Turnaround: The average time from content submission to approval or feedback. If this exceeds 24 hours consistently, you're creating friction that kills momentum. Fast turnaround is one of the most important operational metrics in the program.

Advocate Satisfaction: Measured through periodic surveys. Are advocates enjoying the program? Is compensation fair? Are briefs useful? Would they recommend the program to a peer? An advocate NPS above 50 indicates a healthy program.

Lagging Indicators

Lagging indicators measure the business impact of the program. They're reported monthly and build the ROI case over time.

Total Impressions: Aggregate impressions across all advocate content. This is your reach metric. For context, benchmark it against what equivalent reach would cost through paid advertising.

Engagement Rate: Average likes, comments, and shares per post, expressed as a percentage of impressions. Advocate content on LinkedIn should significantly outperform company page content on this metric. If it doesn't, something about the content or the advocates isn't resonating.

Earned Media Value: The equivalent cost of generating the same impressions and engagement through paid channels. Use conservative CPM benchmarks to keep this

number defensible. This is the metric that finance teams understand.

Pipeline Influence: Deals where the prospect engaged with advocate content before or during the buying process. This is the hardest metric to track and the most important. It requires sales team collaboration, CRM integration, and a willingness to accept that attribution in B2B is never perfectly clean. Track it from Month 3 onward. It gets more meaningful over time.

Inbound Attribution: Leads or demo requests where the prospect specifically cites advocate content, peer recommendations, or advocate referrals as a source. Add "customer recommendation or LinkedIn post" as an option on your demo request form. You'll be surprised how often it gets selected.

Building a Pipeline Influence Tracking System

Pipeline influence is the metric that matters most for justifying ALG investment, and it's the hardest to measure cleanly. Here is a practical approach that balances rigor with realism.

Start with self-reported attribution. Add a field to your demo request form, your CRM's lead source taxonomy, or your sales intake process that captures how the prospect heard about you. Include options like 'customer recommendation,' 'saw a LinkedIn post from a customer,' 'peer referral,' and 'heard about you in a Slack community.' These self-reported signals are imperfect but directionally valuable. Over time, they create a pattern that is hard to dismiss.

Layer in sales-reported touchpoints. Train your AEs to ask, during discovery or later in the sales process, whether the prospect has encountered any customer content about your product. 'Have you come across any of our customers talking about us?' is a natural

question that most prospects will answer honestly. When a prospect says 'actually, I saw a post from [advocate name] on LinkedIn last month and that's what got me curious,' log it. Those data points are gold.

Track engagement data where possible. If you're running Thought Leader Ads, you have Campaign Manager data showing who saw and clicked on advocate content. If an advocate's post includes a link with UTM parameters, you can track downstream behavior. If you're using an ABM platform, you may be able to match LinkedIn engagement data back to target accounts.

Accept that your attribution will be imperfect and build the case anyway. In B2B, the buying journey is long, nonlinear, and influenced by dozens of touchpoints across months. No single-touch attribution model will capture the full impact of advocacy. What you're building is a body of evidence: self-reported signals, sales-reported touchpoints, engagement data, and deal-level anecdotes that together tell a story about how advocacy content is warming your pipeline.

The bar is not mathematical proof. The bar is: does the evidence make it clear that advocate content is influencing buyer behavior in ways that justify the program's cost? In my experience, by Month 6, the answer is obviously yes for any program that's been run well.

CHAPTER 11

ALG Alongside PLG and SLG

Not a replacement, a complement

I want to be very clear about something: Advocacy-Led Growth is not a religion, and it's not asking you to abandon what's already working.

If you have a strong product-led motion, keep it. If you have a sales team that closes deals, keep them. If your content marketing generates inbound, keep doing it. ALG is not a competitive alternative to these strategies. It's the layer that makes all of them work better.

ALG + Product-Led Growth

The standard PLG funnel looks something like: prospect discovers product, signs up for free trial, uses the product, hits a moment of value, converts to paid, expands over time.

The weak link in this chain is the "discovers product" step. In a crowded market, free trials are everywhere. What makes a prospect choose to try your product over the fifteen others in the category? Often, it's because they heard about it from someone they trust.

An advocacy program feeds the top of the PLG funnel with the highest-quality awareness possible. When a prospect signs up for a free trial because they saw a practitioner they

respect posting about the product, that trial user arrives with a higher level of trust, a clearer understanding of the product's value, and a greater likelihood of converting. The PLG machine doesn't change. The quality of what enters it improves.

ALG + Sales-Led Growth

For companies with sales teams, advocacy creates what I think of as "air cover." When a prospect has already seen customers talking positively about your product on LinkedIn, the first sales call is warmer. The buyer has context. They've seen social proof that wasn't orchestrated by the sales team. The conversation starts from a different place.

Advocacy also provides a powerful tool for deal acceleration. When a deal stalls, a sales rep who can share a recent advocate post ("one of our customers just posted about this exact use case, thought you'd find it relevant") has a more credible touchpoint than yet another follow-up email or case study.

And for competitive deals, where the prospect is evaluating multiple vendors, a visible library of customer content creates a trust asymmetry. If your customers are openly talking about you and your competitor's aren't, the buyer notices that gap.

ALG + Content Marketing

Content marketing teams spend enormous effort producing blog posts, whitepapers, videos, and thought leadership. All of that content carries a brand stamp. The reader knows it was produced by the company selling the product.

Advocate content fills a gap that branded content literally cannot fill: the outside perspective. A marketing team can write a blog post about their product's value. They cannot write a genuine first-person account of what it's like to use the product every day.

Only a customer can do that.

The two content streams complement each other. Branded content educates and creates awareness. Advocate content validates and creates trust. Neither one alone is as powerful as both together.

The Integration Playbook

In practical terms, integrating advocacy into your existing growth motions means connecting the advocacy program's output to the systems your other teams are already using. Here is what that looks like in practice.

For PLG integration: your growth team or product team should have access to the advocacy content library organized by use case and feature. When a trial user is exploring a specific feature, the onboarding flow can surface a link to an advocate post about that exact feature. This is not a branded tutorial. It's a real user explaining how they actually use it. The conversion lift from social proof at the moment of evaluation is significant.

For sales integration: your AEs should have a tagged, searchable library of advocate content organized by persona, industry, and buying stage. When an AE is working a deal with a VP of Marketing Operations at a mid-market SaaS company, they should be able to find an advocate post from a VP of Marketing Operations at a mid-market SaaS company talking about the product. That's not a case study. It's a peer speaking in their own voice. The deal team can share it as a natural touchpoint: 'thought you might find this relevant, one of our customers posted about this exact use case.'

For marketing integration: your content calendar should include a rhythm of repurposing advocate content (with permission) into other formats. An advocate's LinkedIn post can become a quote in a blog post, a snippet in a newsletter, a slide in a webinar, or a

testimonial on a landing page. Each repurpose extends the life and reach of content you didn't have to create from scratch.

For customer success integration: your CS team should know which of their accounts include active advocates. Advocates are your most engaged, most loyal customers. They're also the ones most likely to expand their usage, provide product feedback, and resist churn. The advocacy program is not just a marketing tool. It's a retention signal. A customer who is actively advocating for your product is not a churn risk.

The Organizational Home for ALG

One of the most common practical questions I get is: where does the advocacy program sit organizationally?

There is no single right answer, but there are wrong answers. The advocacy program should not sit exclusively in customer success (it becomes an internal-facing reference program). It should not sit exclusively in content marketing (it becomes a content production initiative). It should not sit in demand generation (it becomes a campaign).

The best home for an advocacy program is wherever the company's go-to-market strategy lives. If you have a VP of Marketing who owns pipeline, it sits there. If you have a VP of Growth who owns the full funnel, it sits there. If you're a founder-led company where the CEO drives go-to-market, it reports to you.

The key requirement is that the person who owns the advocacy program has the authority to work across marketing, sales, and customer success. Advocacy touches all three functions. If it's siloed in one of them, it will underperform its potential because it will lack the cross-functional connections that make it work.

CHAPTER 12

The Compounding Effect

Why advocacy programs get stronger over time

The economics of most marketing channels are linear. You spend \$10,000 on ads this month, you get a certain number of impressions. Next month, you spend \$10,000 again and get roughly the same number. There is no memory in the system. Every month starts from zero.

Advocacy-Led Growth has a fundamentally different structure. It compounds.

Content Compounds

A piece of advocate content published in January continues generating impressions in February, March, and beyond. LinkedIn posts have a long tail. They surface in search results. They get reshared. They show up in "people also viewed" recommendations. A library of 100 advocate posts is continuously working in the background, generating impressions and building trust, even when no new content is being published.

Each new piece of content adds to this library. The cumulative effect is that the program's reach grows even if the number of active advocates stays constant. Twelve months of steady advocacy content creates a body of social proof that paid advertising cannot

replicate at any price.

Advocates Recruit Advocates

When a customer participates in an advocacy program and has a positive experience (fair compensation, easy process, increased visibility on their personal LinkedIn profile), they tend to mention it to peers. "I'm part of [Company]'s advocacy program and it's actually good" is itself a form of word-of-mouth.

This creates a recruitment flywheel. First-cohort advocates refer second-cohort advocates. The program grows not just through your CS team's outreach but through organic peer referral within your customer base.

Trust Compounds

The more customer content that exists in the market about your product, the more "searchable trust" you have. When a buyer is evaluating your product and searches LinkedIn for mentions, what do they find? If they find a handful of company posts and a few paid influencer campaigns, that's fine. If they find dozens of genuine customer posts spanning months of authentic experiences, that's a different kind of signal entirely.

That accumulated trust becomes a moat. A competitor entering the market can match your features and undercut your price. They cannot instantly produce twelve months of authentic customer content from verified users. The trust library you build is a competitive asset that compounds over time and is extremely difficult to replicate.

The Advocacy Flywheel

When you put all the compounding effects together, they form a flywheel. Happy customers create content. Content reaches potential buyers. Some of those buyers become customers. The best of those new customers become advocates. Who create more content. Which reaches more buyers.

Every revolution of this flywheel is easier than the last. The first cohort of advocates requires intensive recruitment and onboarding. The second cohort is easier because you have a proven program, live examples of advocate content, and potentially referrals from first-cohort advocates. By the third cohort, the program has enough momentum that recruitment is largely organic.

The content flywheel has a parallel dynamic. Early in the program, every piece of content is isolated. By Month 6, new content links to, references, or builds on earlier content. Advocates see what other advocates have posted and find new angles to explore. The content ecosystem becomes self-reinforcing.

This is fundamentally different from the dynamics of paid advertising, where each impression is independent and the next one costs the same as the last. In an advocacy program, each piece of content makes the next one more likely, more visible, and more valuable. That's the compounding effect, and it's the reason that companies who start building advocacy programs now will have an advantage that late movers cannot quickly close.

Clay: A Public Example

To ground this in a real example, consider Clay, the go-to-market data platform that reached a \$3 billion valuation in 2025. Clay's growth story is, in many ways, a case study in customer-driven advocacy even though they didn't use the ALG label.

Clay built a community of power users who created content showing how they used the product. These users posted workflows, shared templates, and created tutorials on LinkedIn and YouTube. Clay supported this ecosystem by nurturing creator relationships, helping creators with their marketing, hosting events (Clay Clubs in cities around the world), and creating resources that made it easy for users to share their experience.

The compounding effect was visible. User content attracted more users. Those users created more content. The content ecosystem grew into a self-reinforcing flywheel that, alongside Clay's strong product and PLG motion, drove the company to reported revenue of \$100 million by 2025 and a community of over 18,000 active members in their Slack channel.

Clay didn't build a formal advocacy program with rate cards and content briefs in the way this book describes. But the underlying dynamic, customers creating public content that drives growth, is exactly the ALG thesis. The question this book answers is: what does it look like when you build that dynamic intentionally, with infrastructure, from day one?

CHAPTER 12½

What Goes Wrong

Honest lessons from the things that don't work

I've been deliberately optimistic throughout this book because I believe in the thesis. But intellectual honesty requires me to address the ways advocacy programs fail, because they do fail, and understanding the failure modes is as important as understanding the success patterns.

Failure Mode 1: The Program Becomes an Influencer Campaign

This is the most common way advocacy programs die. It usually happens gradually. The marketing team, under pressure to show results, starts treating advocates more like contractors. Briefs get more prescriptive. Deadlines get introduced. Someone creates a content calendar with advocates' names slotted into specific weeks. An executive asks 'why hasn't [advocate] posted this month?' and suddenly the program has performance expectations attached to individual people.

The advocates feel the shift. They went from being valued customers who were invited to share their experience to content producers with implicit quotas. The best advocates, the ones with the most credibility and the biggest audiences, are usually the first to disengage.

They have real jobs and plenty of other demands on their time. They joined because it was interesting and voluntary. The moment it feels like an obligation, the math changes.

The content quality degrades too. Posts that were once genuine reflections on the product start reading like marketing copy. The engagement drops. The buyers who were resonating with the authentic voice start scrolling past. The program is still producing content, but it's no longer producing trust.

The fix is structural, not motivational. If your program is drifting toward assignment, the problem isn't the advocates. It's the incentives and expectations within your own organization. Revisit the organic principle. Remove deadlines. Stop tracking individual output. Refocus the team on creating conditions for content, not demanding content.

Failure Mode 2: Wrong Advocates, Right Program

Not every happy customer is a good advocate. I've seen programs recruit customers who love the product but hate creating content. They agreed to participate because the CSM asked nicely and they didn't want to say no. They go through onboarding, look at the briefs, and never produce anything. This isn't a failure of the program. It's a failure of recruitment targeting.

The ideal advocate has three characteristics: they genuinely like the product, they are already somewhat active on social platforms (they post about their work occasionally, even if infrequently), and they have an audience that overlaps with your ICP. Missing any one of these three makes advocacy a heavy lift.

A customer who loves the product but never posts on LinkedIn will struggle to start. A customer who posts regularly but is ambivalent about the product will produce content that lacks conviction. A customer who loves the product and posts regularly but works in a

completely different industry from your ICP will generate engagement that doesn't translate to pipeline.

The fix is better qualification during recruitment. Don't just ask CS for their happiest customers. Ask for their happiest customers who are also active on LinkedIn. Do the social listening research before making the introduction. A smaller cohort of well-matched advocates will outperform a larger cohort of poorly matched ones every time.

Failure Mode 3: Compensation That Feels Transactional

Compensation is a tricky balance. Pay too little and advocates feel undervalued. Pay too much and the relationship starts feeling like a content production deal rather than a recognition program. The worst outcome is when advocates start to feel like they're being paid for their opinion rather than for their time.

The framing matters enormously. The compensation should feel like a thank-you for the time and effort of creating content, not like a fee for a positive review. The distinction is subtle but real. When an advocate feels they're being compensated for their time, they create honest, nuanced content. When they feel they're being paid for enthusiasm, the content becomes performative.

Published, transparent rates help with this. When everyone can see that a LinkedIn post pays \$100 regardless of whether it's glowing praise or balanced feedback, the transactional pressure drops. The advocate knows they'll get paid for creating quality content, period. They don't need to manufacture enthusiasm to earn their rate.

Failure Mode 4: No One Closes the Loop

I've seen advocacy programs that produce great content, generate meaningful impressions, and clearly influence pipeline, but no one inside the company can prove it. The sales team doesn't know the program exists. There's no mechanism to track whether prospects encountered advocate content. The monthly report shows content metrics but can't connect them to revenue.

This is a slow death. The program works, but because its impact is invisible to the people who control budget, it eventually gets defunded in favor of channels with cleaner attribution. The paid ad campaign that can show a direct line from click to demo request wins the budget fight, even though the advocacy program may be generating more actual pipeline influence through unmeasured channels.

The fix is to build measurement into the program from day one. Add 'customer recommendation or LinkedIn post' as a source option on your demo request form. Train sales to ask prospects what they've heard about you. Create a simple process for sales to flag deals where advocate content played a role. Accept that attribution in B2B will never be perfectly clean, and build a preponderance-of-evidence case rather than waiting for perfect data.

Failure Mode 5: The Program Depends on One Person

If your advocacy program is run by a single person who holds all the advocate relationships, manages the briefs, processes the payouts, and produces the reports, you have a key-person risk that will eventually materialize. People change roles. They go on leave. They leave the company. And when they do, the program collapses because everything was in their head.

This is why documented operations matter. Every process should be written down in step-by-step detail. Every advocate relationship should be tracked in a system, not in someone's inbox. Every payout should be processed through a platform with a clear audit trail. The test of operational maturity is: could someone new take over this program in two weeks and run it competently? If the answer is no, you have documentation work to do.

Failure Mode 6: Expecting Results Too Fast

Advocacy-Led Growth compounds, which is its great strength and its great challenge. The compounding means it gets dramatically better over time. It also means the first 60 to 90 days look underwhelming compared to the immediate gratification of turning on a LinkedIn ad campaign.

A company that launches an advocacy program, sees modest results in Month 2, and pulls the plug in Month 3 has made a mistake they'll never know about. The program would have been generating meaningful returns by Month 6 and strong returns by Month 12. But because the early returns are modest, and because there's always pressure to shift budget to channels with faster feedback loops, the program gets killed before the compounding has a chance to work.

The fix is to set expectations accurately at the start. Advocacy is a 6-to-12-month investment, not a 30-day experiment. The early months are about building infrastructure, recruiting advocates, and establishing content patterns. The returns come later, and they come with a compounding curve that paid channels cannot match. Communicate this to every stakeholder before the program launches, and hold the line when the inevitable 'is this working yet?' question comes in Month 2.

CHAPTER 13

Getting Started

Practical first steps

If you've read this far and you're convinced the thesis has merit, the natural question is: where do I start?

Here's what I'd recommend, regardless of your company stage.

Step 1: Audit What You Already Have

Before building anything, look at what's already happening. Search LinkedIn for mentions of your product. Search X. Check G2 and other review sites. Ask your CS team: which customers are already talking about us publicly?

You may be surprised. Most B2B SaaS companies with even a modest customer base have customers who have already created organic content about them. Those people are your Tier 1 advocate candidates, and you haven't even asked them yet.

Step 2: Have the Conversations

Pick five of your happiest customers. Not your biggest logos. Your happiest users. The ones your CS team would describe as genuine fans.

Have a conversation. Not a pitch. Not a recruitment call. Just a conversation: "We're thinking about building a program where customers can share their experience with [Product] publicly, and we'd compensate them for their time. Would something like that interest you? What would make it worth your while?"

The answers will tell you whether you have the raw material for an advocacy program. If four out of five say some version of "I'd do that" or "I've actually been meaning to write about this," you have something to work with.

Step 3: Start Small and Learn

Run a pilot with 8 to 12 advocates. Keep it simple. Publish a handful of content briefs as optional prompts. Set transparent compensation rates. Use whatever tools you have (even a spreadsheet and Venmo) to manage the first cycle. The operational infrastructure can be built up as you learn.

The goal of the pilot is not to generate massive reach. It's to answer three questions: Do advocates actually create content? Is the content credible and engaging? Can you build an operational process around it that's sustainable?

If the answer to all three is yes, you have the foundation for a real program. Scale from there.

Step 4: Measure and Build the Case

From day one, track everything. Impressions, engagement, content volume, advocate satisfaction. Start tracking pipeline influence as soon as you can. Build the EMV calculation so you have a dollar figure to compare against your paid spend.

The internal case for advocacy funding gets stronger with every month of data. By Month 3, you should have enough to demonstrate that the channel is real. By Month 6, you should have enough to justify a formal budget allocation.

Step 5: Scale What Works

Once your pilot has proven the three core questions (advocates will create, the content resonates, you can operationalize it), the path forward is expansion. Recruit a second cohort of advocates, drawing from what you learned about ideal advocate profiles in the first cohort. Expand your brief library based on which topics generated the most engagement. Begin Thought Leader Ad amplification on your top-performing posts. Integrate pipeline influence tracking with your CRM.

The scaling motion should feel natural, not forced. If your first cohort went well, several of those advocates will refer peers. Your CS team, having seen the results, will be more enthusiastic about making introductions. Your marketing team will want more of the content that's outperforming their branded material.

By Month 6 of a well-run program, you should have 15 to 25 active advocates producing 30 to 50 pieces of content per month, with measurable pipeline influence and a clear EMV comparison to your paid channels. By Month 12, advocacy should be a recognized, budgeted channel within your go-to-market organization, with its own metrics, its own operational owner, and its own trajectory.

A Note on Timing

I'm often asked when a company is 'ready' for advocacy-led growth. The honest answer is: earlier than you think.

You don't need thousands of customers. You need 50 or more active users with genuine product experience. You don't need a huge marketing team. You need one person willing to invest a few hours per week in program management. You don't need a formal platform on day one. You need a spreadsheet, a Venmo account, and a willingness to experiment.

The companies that wait for the 'right time' to start an advocacy program are usually waiting for a moment of maturity that never arrives cleanly. Meanwhile, their competitors are building trust with every advocate post that goes live.

My advice: start messy, start small, and start now. The compound clock starts ticking when the first advocate post goes live. Every month you wait is a month of compounding you don't get back.

CHAPTER 14

The Future of B2B Growth

Where this is heading

I'll keep this chapter short because I'm more interested in what you do with the framework than in my predictions about the future. But a few observations about where B2B growth is headed, and why advocacy will matter more, not less, as these trends accelerate.

AI Changes the Content Landscape

Generative AI is making it trivially easy to produce branded content. Blog posts, email sequences, ad copy, social posts: all of it can now be generated at a fraction of the historical cost. The inevitable result is a flood of AI-generated B2B content that is competent, on-message, and utterly indistinguishable from everything else.

In a world where every company can produce unlimited content at near-zero cost, the content itself stops being a differentiator. What differentiates is the source. A post from a real practitioner sharing a real experience, written in their own imperfect, human voice, will stand out against a sea of polished AI-generated brand content precisely because it is visibly, unmistakably human.

AI is also changing how buyers research products. Increasingly, buyers are using AI tools to generate vendor lists, summarize product capabilities, and surface comparative information. The inputs to those AI tools are the public web: the content that exists about your product across social platforms, review sites, and professional communities. A rich body of authentic customer content isn't just valuable for human readers. It's training data for the AI systems that are increasingly mediating the buyer journey.

Trust Becomes the Scarcest Resource

Every trend in B2B marketing is converging on a single constraint: trust. Buyers are more skeptical. Content is more abundant and less differentiated. Sales outreach is more automated and less personal. AI-generated content is making it harder to distinguish genuine perspective from machine-produced marketing.

In this environment, the companies that have invested in building trust through their customer base will have an advantage that is nearly impossible to replicate quickly. You can spin up an ad campaign in a week. You can launch a content strategy in a month. You cannot build a library of authentic customer advocacy in less than six months to a year. The companies that start now will have a structural lead over those who wait.

The Operating System Emerges

I believe we're in the early innings of a category shift. The tools, the platforms, the operational frameworks for running advocacy as a real growth channel are just starting to emerge. Within a few years, I expect ALG to be as established a part of the B2B growth playbook as PLG and SLG are today.

The companies that build their advocacy muscle now, that invest in the infrastructure, relationships, and operational discipline to run this channel well, will be the ones that define how the category matures. They'll have the data, the case studies, and the competitive advantage that comes from being early in a structural shift.

That's the opportunity. And that's why I started Kindling.

The Convergence of GTM Motions

I expect the next five years to produce a convergence of growth motions rather than a succession of replacements. The most effective B2B SaaS companies will not be 'PLG companies' or 'sales-led companies' or 'advocacy-led companies.' They will be companies that run all three motions in a coordinated way, with each one feeding the others.

Product-led growth creates the user base. Sales-led growth closes the enterprise deals. Advocacy-led growth builds the trust that makes both of those motions more effective. The company that masters this convergence will have a growth engine that is far more resilient and efficient than any single-motion competitor.

Advocacy has a unique role in this convergence because it is the one motion that is genuinely customer-driven. PLG is still company-initiated (you build the product and the funnel). SLG is still company-initiated (you hire the reps and run the process). ALG is the only growth motion where the primary content and distribution comes from outside the company. That's what makes it both harder to build and harder to replicate.

The Next Decade of B2B Marketing

If I had to bet on what B2B marketing looks like in 2035, my bet would be this: the companies that win will be the ones whose customers are visibly, publicly, and authentically talking about them. Not because they were asked to. Not because they were paid to. But because the product is good enough and the relationship is strong enough that sharing the experience feels natural.

The role of the marketing team will shift from creating content to creating the conditions for content. From buying attention to earning trust. From controlling the narrative to supporting the narrators.

That shift is already happening. This book is my attempt to give it a name, a framework, and a system. I hope it's useful.

Afterword

About Kindling

Kindling is the operating system for Advocacy-Led Growth. It's the platform my team and I are building to make everything described in this book operationally real.

The platform handles the full lifecycle of an advocacy program: recruiting verified customer advocates, publishing transparent rate cards, making content briefs available as optional inspiration, tracking what advocates create, managing the review process, processing compensation through Stripe Connect, and measuring the program's impact on reach, engagement, and pipeline.

We also offer done-for-you consulting engagements for companies that want to stand up an ALG program with hands-on operational support. These engagements run 90 to 180 days and include everything from strategy development through full program handoff with documented operational procedures.

If the framework in this book resonated with you, I'd love to talk. You can book a conversation at:

calendly.com/degroodt/kindling

kindlinghq.com

And if you're not ready for a conversation but found value in this book, the best thing you can do is share it with someone who's thinking about the same problems. Forward the PDF. Post about it on LinkedIn. Tell a founder or a marketing leader who's struggling with the same challenges.

That, after all, is advocacy.

Notes

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The Advocacy Operating System

First Edition

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Credibility lives in people, not brands.